



FIRST IN-FLIGHT MOVIE

The first in-flight movie was shown to passengers on a Deutsche Luft Hansa flight on April 6, 1925. Due to weight limitations, single-reel shorts were generally shown; the fact that the films were silent made them ideal for showing in a noisy airliner. Note the wicker chairs, standard in most passenger aircraft in the 1920s.

SITTING COMFORTABLY

Passengers on a Deutsche Luft Hansa flight of the late 1920s, traveling in a Junkers G 24 trimotor, enjoyed reasonable comfort with no frills. Notice that everyone has kept their coat on since the cabins were not heated. The Germans were world leaders in passenger aviation until well into the 1930s.

McGinnis. The key to its initial success was that it served two towns, Charleville and Cloncurry, that were 600 miles (960km) apart and had no other viable means of communication. But Qantas could no more survive without government handouts than could any other airline, depending on a generous contract to carry airmail. From 1928, Qantas also provided the aircraft for the first “flying doctor” service in the outback.

South America was another area of the world where air travel could radically cut journey times between towns and cities with otherwise inadequate or circuitous transportation links. Despite the challenge posed by jungle and mountain terrain, in the early 1920s air transportation made more progress in South America than North America.

PARIS TO LONDON: A PILOT’S EXPERIENCE

IN THE EARLY 1920s, pilot Frank Courtney described the experience of flying a D.H.34 on a passenger service from Le Bourget, Paris, to Croydon, London, in poor weather conditions: “While taxiing out to takeoff, I am getting wet and uncomfortable because of the open cockpit. Once airborne, though still comparatively close to the ground, we are just below cloud. I start on the usual compass course with a mentally calculated allowance for drift... but after six miles I find there are tree-covered hills shrouded in wisps of cloud. It is now obvious that a compass course is impossible, so I turn left and pick up the main road from Paris to Boulogne... [I] am compelled to stick to this road as completely as a motor car, for if I lose sight of it I am to all intents and purposes lost...” Eventually he has to abandon following the road to Boulogne because it leads over hills where cloud is

at treetop height. Even then he does not dare cut across country, but has to trace the road back to a junction. There he follows an alternative road to Amiens. He finally crosses the Channel, reaches England’s white cliffs and finds a circuitous route to Croydon that avoids cloud-covered hills. Courtney’s concluding remarks were not reassuring: “Completion of the journey has been entirely dependent on what risks the pilot was prepared to take, and there is the added fact that on such a flight... the avoidance of a collision with a machine coming in the other direction is frequently a matter of luck.”

BRAVING THE WEATHER

While the passengers traveling from Paris to London enjoyed relative comfort inside the cabin, the pilot remained largely exposed to the elements.

